

Eleven Minutes

Ten years before. Eleven minutes. Two unhurried men who knew his name.

Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

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Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Ten years ago. GLMZ, Lower District.

The air tasted like copper and burnt plastic, the way it always did after a storm hit the industrial tier — rain still dripping from the overhead pipes, pooling in the corrugated seams of the service corridor. Kyle stood at the edge of it, back against the wall, breathing slow.

The wound is already there. You are only now noticing it.

His left hand was wet. He didn't look at it.

Three floors below, a man named Deshi Okafor was still alive because Kyle had made a choice. The kind that hollows something out of you before you've finished making it, and you don't know what's missing until you reach for it later.

You're bleeding. You're standing in a corridor that smells like someone else's last hour. Stop pretending this is fine.

The katana was sheathed. That was the discipline — not the blade, but the sheath. Anyone could cut. The work was in the restraint, in the moment before. Kyle had chosen. He was still holding that choice upright, the way you hold something heavy when you're not sure you're allowed to put it down.

A man who will not look at his wound will not survive it.

He finally looked at his hand. The gash ran from the base of his thumb to somewhere he couldn't see without moving fabric. Not deep enough to be serious. Deep enough to be a reminder. He pressed it against his jacket and walked.

The corridor opened onto a maintenance catwalk above the district's lower tier — forty meters of vertical city, neon and rain and the low industrial hum of a megastructure that had long since stopped distinguishing between its working parts and its failing ones. Somewhere in that vertical mile, Deshi Okafor was telling someone what Kyle had done. Or what Kyle hadn't done. Kyle wasn't sure which version was worse.

He's going to sell you. You know he's going to sell you. You let him walk anyway.

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Deshi Okafor has a daughter. You saw the photograph. You looked away from it, but you saw it.

He stopped at the railing. Looked down. The city moved below him like something alive and indifferent, and he thought about the contract, about the woman who had hired him, about the specific and careful words she had used when she said *no witnesses*. He had nodded. He had taken the money. He had meant it, at the time, the way you mean things when the cost is still theoretical.

The code was never about what you would do. It was always about what you would not.

The rain found a gap in his collar. Cold. Real. He turned from the railing and walked toward the elevator, and he did not run, because running was a different kind of answer, and he wasn't ready to give it yet.

The elevator was broken. Of course it was. He took the stairs.

You took the money first. Remember that. You took the money and then you decided to have a conscience. That's not a moral position. That's a sequence of events you're trying to reorder after the fact.

Four flights down, a woman was sitting on a landing with her back against the wall and a child asleep across her knees. She had the careful stillness of someone who had learned not to draw attention. Kyle stepped around them without slowing. He did not make eye contact. He left two chips on the step beside her hand — not enough to matter, not nothing — and kept moving.

That's not absolution. Don't mistake it for absolution.

He knew. He wasn't mistaking it for anything. It was just two chips on a step, and the woman hadn't moved, and he didn't know if she'd take them or leave them, and he kept walking because stopping to answer that question was its own kind of answer.



The contact point was a repair shop six blocks east, the kind that fixed things no one was supposed to own. Kyle pushed through the beaded curtain and stood in the smell of flux and

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old oil while a man named Carver looked up from a circuit board and read his face the way mechanics read machines — not for what they're saying, but for what they're about to do.

"Hand," Carver said. Not a question.

Kyle set it on the counter. Carver worked without ceremony — antiseptic, closure strips, tape — the practiced efficiency of someone who had learned not to ask. The shop smelled like every repair shop Kyle had ever bled in, and he thought that was probably a thing worth noticing about his life, and then he stopped thinking about it.

The woman on the stairs may have taken the chips. Or she may have left them there for the next person, the way you leave water in the desert for someone you will never meet. You will not know. That's the shape of it.

Carver finished and said a number. Kyle paid it. He pulled his sleeve down over the tape and stood there one moment longer than he needed to, because somewhere in the last hour he had crossed something he couldn't name yet, and he wanted to mark it, even if only in the way a man stands still in a repair shop in GLMZ while the rain comes down outside and the city continues its enormous indifferent work.

You will carry Okafor's name. Not as penance. As a record. Someone should.

He walked out into the rain.



Three blocks became four. The rain thickened. Kyle moved through the lower district's arterial corridor — a canyon of stacked habitation units and dead signage, the neon bled out by water into something that looked like bruising. He was calculating the distance between himself and the next twelve hours, which was the only mathematics that mattered at street level after a job went sideways.

A path chosen in haste is still a path. The feet remember what the mind forgets.

He heard the second man before he saw him — the specific quality of stillness that isn't stillness, the way a body holds itself when it's waiting rather than resting. The doorway was recessed, unlit. Kyle had already begun to turn when the first shot came, not from the

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doorway but from above, from somewhere in the grating overhead, and it was not a bullet. It was a directed pulse — low-frequency, the kind that leaves no entry wound and scrambles cardiac rhythm like a hand reaching into a chest and closing. He felt it arrive before he understood what it was. A pressure. A wrongness. The city tilted.

You should have run. I told you. I told you to run.

Even the sword that is never drawn — rusts.

He was on the concrete before he decided to fall. The rain hit his face in thin cold threads, the same rain, the same city, the same enormous indifferent work continuing above and around him while something in his chest stuttered and grabbed and could not find its rhythm. He was aware of footsteps — two sets, unhurried, the walk of men who had already confirmed the outcome. He was aware of the photograph, still in Okafor's pocket, three floors up and six blocks west. He was aware, with the specific clarity that arrives only when the body begins its final accounting, that the woman on the stairs had probably left the chips.

You will not finish this thought. That is also the shape of it.

The footsteps stopped. A voice said something in a dialect he half-knew, technical and flat, the language of a work order being completed. He felt hands — not rough, almost clinical — and then a different kind of pressure in his chest, lower than the wound, deliberate, the sensation of something being placed rather than taken. Cold metal. A faint harmonic, like a tuning fork held against bone. Then nothing. Then the rain. Then not even that.



He came back to himself in increments. First the smell — flux, oil, the specific sweetness of scorched synthetic protein, which meant Carver's shop, which meant someone had carried him. Then the light, orange and low, pressing against his eyelids like something with weight. Then the pain, which arrived last, the way pain does when the body has been conserving it.

Someone put you back together. Ask yourself why.

He did not sit up immediately. He catalogued first — ceiling, familiar; hands, both present;

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chest, wrong. Not injured-wrong. *Different*-wrong. The kind of different that has been there long enough to start pretending it belongs. He pressed two fingers below his sternum and felt the faint harmonic, the tuning-fork resonance he had no memory of acquiring, already learning the rhythm of his breathing, already quiet enough to mistake for himself.

The thing placed inside a man in the dark does not announce itself. It waits.

Carver was at the workbench with his back turned, doing something small and precise with both hands. He did not turn when Kyle moved. He said, "You were down eleven minutes." He said it the way a mechanic reports a diagnostic — not comfort, not apology, just the number. Kyle looked at the ceiling and thought about eleven minutes, about what had been done to him inside those eleven minutes, about the hands he had described to himself as *almost clinical*, and he understood, with the flat and total understanding of a man who has run out of useful denials, that the word *almost* had been doing a great deal of work.

You will want to ask Carver what he knows. You will not ask. Because if he answers, you will have to decide what to do with the answer, and you are not ready. That is the truth. Carry it.

He sat up slowly. The shop tilted once and then held. Carver still hadn't turned.

Ask him. You're going to live with this either way. At least know what you're living with.

Kyle put his feet on the floor. The concrete was cold through his boots, real and specific, and he used that. He looked at his chest — jacket closed, no visible alteration, nothing to see. That was the worst part. That it looked like nothing. He pressed two fingers below his sternum again and the harmonic answered him, patient, already fluent in the rhythm of his lungs.

A man can be rewritten in eleven minutes. The body does not protest what it cannot name.

"Who carried me," Kyle said. Not a question. A test.

Carver set down his tool. He turned, finally, and his face had the specific blankness of a man who has decided in advance what he will and will not give. "Two men. They knew where to bring you." He picked up the tool again. "They knew your name." He said it without emphasis, which was its own kind of emphasis, and Kyle sat with that — the image of two unhurried men carrying his body through GLMZ's arterial corridor, through the rain,

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through the beaded curtain, setting him down with the care of people delivering something valuable, something they intended to use again.

You did not choose this. That matters. It does not change anything, but it matters. Hold the difference.

He stood. His legs held. He pulled his jacket straight with one hand, the other still taped, and he walked to the curtain. He stopped there — not hesitation, just the pause of a man taking the last clear measure of where he stood before the ground changed under him. He pressed two fingers below his sternum once more. The harmonic answered, patient, already fluent in the rhythm of his lungs. He had not put it there. It had learned him anyway. He let his hand drop and pushed through the curtain into the rain.

For ten years after that night, Kyle did not ask what had been placed inside him. He told himself there was no reason to ask. He had been, he now understood, standing in the Weld junction with a girl's map open between them, very careful never to have a reason.

